

Brother DCP-7010

Decent, we say!

Compact with a footprint of 43.2 x 39.5 cm (which is quite small), the DCP-7010 is a mono laser printer, scanner and copier, but does not feature standalone fax functionality; you need to use it in conjunction with a PC to send faxes.

The printer has a claimed hardware resolution of 2400 x 600 dpi—rather high for an entry-level product. In our tests, this one took 19.1 seconds to warm up, and 10.3 seconds for the first text print. Print quality was average for text in Draft mode, but improved a lot in the best mode.

The scanner resolution is 600 x 2400 at 24-bit colour, and it supports a maximum paper size of A4. The scanner is a bit slow: it took 13.7 seconds for a mono scan, which is on the higher side for a scanner with the WIA driver interface. A full-colour A4 photo scan at 600 dpi takes just under 4 minutes, again very slow. The machine reproduced colours fairly well—we'd say it's good enough for

scanning photographs. The OCR test didn't see it fare well, however.

The printer features the USB and even the parallel interface (the latter for those with older computers). The MFL-Pro suite—a control centre to take care of jobs such as scanning, faxing, and more—is good, and also bundled is PaperPort 9.0SE (OCR software). The claimed printer duty cycle is 10,000 prints per month, while the toner has a duty cycle of 2,500. The DCP-7010 is decently priced (Rs 11,150); the toner cartridge costs Rs 2,150, meaning the cost per print is 86 paise. We still recommend this MFD because of portability, speed, and overall performance.



Panasonic KX-FLB802CX

A super-value copier

The Panasonic KX-FLB802CX is in a class of its own: it is the only copier-based MFD we tested. Being copier-based, it comes with separate drum and toner cartridges. The advantage of such a device over printer-based MFDs is this: the toner and drum have different duty cycles, and the drum's duty cycle is always more than twice that of the toner. In the case of printer-based laser MFDs, the toner and drum are integrated, and the duty cycle of the single unit is that of the toner—so you have to replace the whole thing even when the drum's duty cycle hasn't been expended. With copier-based laser MFDs, you need to change either the toner or drum as and when its duty cycle is over. This proves to be cost-effective. However, copier-based units have traditionally been more expensive to manufacture. This one breaks the mould, and costs just Rs 15,999.

At 44 x 44.5 cm, this MFD occupies a comparatively large area, but can just about fit beside a PC on a regular desktop. Installing the drum is very easy, but installing the cartridge is not. Input tray capacity is 250 sheets, and there is also a multipurpose tray for additional paper storage.

The printer supports 600 x 600 dpi. The initialisation time of this MFD is just under 20 seconds. For the text document, it took 14.7 seconds to print the first copy and thereafter printed at 16 ppm. It takes a couple of seconds longer to print the first copy of the combi-document, but thereafter prints at just about the same speed as the text print. Text is quite sharp, and inverse text was pretty good, too.

The scanner supports 600 x 1200 dpi, but the driver doesn't support the newer WIA interface—which many modern scanners do, because it is more standardised. The scanner is good at capturing colours and fine details, but is extremely slow, especially at resolutions lower than 600 dpi. Since

these are the resolutions at which people most often scan documents and even photographs, the scanner loses out on performance points. It

took 27.2 seconds to scan a monochrome document at 200 dpi, while a colour document at 600 dpi took just over 2 minutes—pretty good. The scanner did not fare well in the OCR test, committing 25 mistakes, which is bad.

The first copy took 18.3 seconds. We found the copies rather dark, and as a result, the inverse text was not very legible. Fine print didn't turn out legible, either.

This is the only contender that comes with a handset, which doubles up as a phone if you are using your phone line for fax (as is the case with most SoHo users). It can store up to 170 pages of incoming fax in case it runs out of toner. The hardware junk fax prohibitor filters out faxes from unwanted numbers, using caller ID.

The interface is USB, though there is the option to upgrade to an Ethernet port interface. The MFD comes with Readiris 7 OCR, Remote Control PCFAX to send faxes via the PC, and a Network Scan Module, which helps deploy the machine over a network. The duty cycle of the printer is 10,000, which is the same as that of its drum, while the toner cartridge has a duty cycle of 2,500. Cost per page comes out to be Rs 1.20—a bit on the higher side for a laser MFD. Still, like we said, it's cheap for a copier-based MFD.

